Event Report: Publishing Careers with Philip Leventhal

On February 19th, I attended the Department of English's Career Series event titled *Careers in Publishing* featuring guest speaker Philip Leventhal. Leventhal was a visiting Senior Executive Editor from Columbia University Press. The event was held both in-person and broadcast virtually, where I attended it via Teams. The event was not recorded. It focused on discussing the professional pathways under the umbrella of publishing careers, particularly those involving the differences between university press and trade publishing. Although my major is in Information Science with a concentration on Data Science & Analytics, my minor is in Creative Writing. After over six hundred unsuccessful job applications related to my major, I decided to explore what the possibilities are for employment using my minor. Publishing, in its various iterations, is often cited as a desirable career for many English scholars and other aspiring information professionals. Relating this event to my own career goals revealed clarifying new insights that sobered my career expectations.

One of the most surprising aspects of Leventhal's presentation was his emphasis on communication and administrative work in this career field. He noted that many new graduates assume that publishing careers involve a lot of reading, but this is not always the case. Although editing manuscripts and engaging with literature are a part of this field, much of the work done by publishing professionals involves researching, corresponding through email, managing paperwork, and especially in the case of academic publishing, coordinating with experts in specific fields to review written works (Leventhal, 2026). For example, Leventhal noted that in university press publishing, experts in related fields must evaluate manuscripts and complete questionnaires about their contents while editorial staff primarily processes and manages the

documentation for these activities. Learning this reframed my understanding of the daily activities of information professionals engaged in university press publication.

Leventhal also discussed the financial realities of publishing, noting that it can cost "approximately $30,000 to publish a book" (Leventhal, 2026). Leventhal noted that profitable returns on university press publications are often times less than the cost of producing the book. This is because these publications are often intended for a small, academic audience in a niche field (Leventhal, 2026). However, universities still endeavor to engage in this kind of publication because their mission is to facilitate academic communication rather than generate profits from a mass audience. By contrast, fiction publishing, especially in the trade market, often prioritizes authors who have the best odds of generating the greatest amount of profit. In the modern era, this can include authors who already have an established online presence via a substantial social media following. In some cases, trade publishers are even known to approach writers specifically because of their existing social media success (Leventhal, 2026). Therefore, the requirements for establishing a career in publishing can be quite different depending on whether or not one is interested in pursuing university press publication or mass market publication.

Another important takeaway from Leventhal's publication careers talk was the difficulty of securing entry-level roles. He emphasized that becoming an editor is "difficult" despite the common assumption that publishing careers revolve around editorial skills such as those of recent English graduates (Leventhal, 2026). Similarly, he noted that it is difficult to become a literary agent. According to Leventhal, for students interested in becoming a literary agent, these professionals often begin their careers as editors. He stressed that prior experience in publishing is often required to obtain a job in publishing, creating an infinite loop that can be discouraging for students (Leventhal, 2026). However, he also pointed to resources such as Publishers Weekly,

Shelf Awareness, and the Association of University Presses job board as industry-specific platforms where students can locate and stay informed about job opportunities. He encouraged students to pursue internships during college, suggesting that those interested reach out to Dr. Shuman about potential internship placement opportunities (Leventhal, 2026).

Relating this event to my own career goals was both sobering and clarifying. After reflecting on the information shared by Mr. Leventhal and my own lack of success job hunting, I have become increasingly aware of how important adaptability and transferable skills are in information-adjacent career fields. Attending this event confirmed that my Creative Writing minor itself will not automatically open doors in publishing. However, it did highlight the fact that I already possess many of the minimum skills to pursue a career in publishing or related fields, such as: research skills, filling out paperwork, corresponding professionally via email, and collaborating with others. Whether or not these skills lead to career success comes down to how those skills are marketed to employers, what prior experience and connections one has, and finally, knowing where to look to find the right opportunity at the right time.

References

Leventhal, P. (2026, February 19). *Careers in publishing.* [Hybrid presentation]. Department of English, University of South Florida. https://www.usf.edu/arts-sciences/departments/english/undergraduate/career-series.aspx